

Chagrin Falls can't keep up with Wauseon



Chagrin Falls' Katie Carson, right, and Laura Miller go after the ball. Carson had 16 points and 23 rebounds in the Tigers' loss to Wauseon in the Division III state championship game.

By DICK ZUNT
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

COLUMBUS — Chagrin Falls fell to unbeaten Wauseon, 71-49, yesterday in the Division III girls basketball state championship game in front of 5,965 in St. John Arena.

Wauseon outscored the Tigers, 25-6, in the second quarter to break the game open, taking a 41-20 halftime lead.

Wauseon, ranked No. 3 in the final Associated Press poll, finished 27-0 and won the championship in its first appearance in the final four.

Chagrin Falls, ranked No. 4, finished 26-2 and brought home the silver state runner-up trophy.

Chagrin Falls was making its fourth trip to the state tournament, its first under coach Frank Phillips. The school also lost in the 1983 state title game.

Chagrin Falls held a 14-13 lead after a putback field goal by 5-10 junior Katie Carson with 48.3 seconds left in the first quarter.

But Wauseon's 5-11 junior Katie Griggs sank the first of her five 3-point field goals with 30.8 seconds left for a 16-14 lead at the end of the quarter.

Griggs, who led all scorers with 21 points, drove for a layup 10 seconds into the second quarter, and Chagrin Falls was unable to keep up with the pace of the fast-breaking Indians.

Wauseon, which sank nine 3-point field goals in 14 attempts, drenched the Tigers' title hopes in a shower of 3-pointers and second-quarter free-throw accuracy.

Wauseon converted 9 of 11 free throws in the second quarter.

Wauseon came out aggressive and stayed aggressive, filling the floor with full-length passes, which helped result in 25 field goals in 56 attempts on the way to a record number of points for a Division III title game.

Carson, the goalie on Chagrin Falls' state championship soccer team, had 23 rebounds — possibly a tournament best, but that record is not kept.

"We played pretty good basketball in the first quarter and missed some other close shots that could have given us the lead," said coach Phillips.

"But in the second quarter their pressure caused us to rush what we did, and the momentum began to swing in their favor. We would have liked to have played a



Trish Kruse shoots a layup for Chagrin Falls, cutting between Stacy Roth, left, and Kelly Burgei of Wauseon.

more steady game, but we were never able to get it done.

"That is an exceptional basketball team with five athletes who all can jump and handle the ball well," Phillips said of Wauseon. "They are demoralizing. They are unselfish, an attribute of a state championship team."

"We tried to pass over them instead of bouncing our passes."

Chagrin Falls started one senior, 6-0 Kelly Haase, who picked up her third foul with 4:29 left in the second quarter and came out of the game. Her play was limited the rest of the way.

Carson's 16 points led her team. Katie Kruse had 11 points for the

Tigers, who will be honored tomorrow with a community reception in the high school gymnasium at 1:45 p.m.

"We never faced a team with perimeter shooting like Wauseon," Carson said. "I have no complaints, I'm happy we got here."

"Our concern going in was Chagrin Falls' size," said Wauseon coach Brad Myers. "The key was to get out and press them and keep the ball away from their post players. We used a 1-3-1 zone."

"For the most part, we did a pretty good job of keeping the ball away from them," said Myers, in his eighth year at the school.

Tigers' Phillips sizes up Wauseon as one of the best

By TIM ROGERS
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

COLUMBUS — If you have to lose in a state championship basketball game, you like to think you have lost to the best.

Chagrin Falls coach Frank Phillips, whose team lost to Wauseon, 71-49, in the Division III championship game, left St. John Arena yesterday feeling good.

"We have nothing to be ashamed about," Phillips said. "We not only lost to the best team in Division III, but we lost to what I consider to be one of the best

teams in Ohio in any division."

How good were the Indians? Probably better than their third-place rating in the final state-wide poll by the Associated Press.

For starters, they finished the season as Ohio's only undefeated girls basketball team. There are 775 schools in Ohio that have girls basketball teams. Wauseon won 27 consecutive games.

Yesterday's 22-point victory was the largest margin of victory in a Division III state title game. The old record was 18 when Heath beat Sherwood Fairview,

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FRANK PHILLIPS, Chagrin Falls coach

62-44, in 1991.

The 71 points that Wauseon scored were the most in a Division III state championship game. The old record was set in 1995 by St. Vincent-St. Mary, which defeated Sherwood Fairview, 66-62.

Wauseon made nine 3-pointers, breaking the Division III record of seven set by SVSM in the '95 title game.

Wauseon junior Katie Griggs, the Northwest district player of the year and an all-

Ohioan, made five 3-pointers. That tied the Division III record for most 3-pointers by an individual, set by Natalie Hill, of Chillicothe Unioto, in 1989.

The two teams also combined for 11 3-pointers and 53 free throws, both Division III records.

"I feel Wauseon could compete in any division," said Phillips, who had a team in the state championship game for the first time. "They can score inside or outside and they can rebound. But, what I think sets them apart from everyone else is that all of them can

handle the ball and are willing to work to create things. They are extremely unselfish."

While Phillips seemed to take the loss more in stride than his players, the veteran of 30 seasons got choked up when asked if the trip was worth the wait.

"It is humbling to be in St. John Arena," he said before pausing to regain his composure. "As someone who's been in the game for 30 years and has come to many state tournaments and watched other coaches and dreamed... and his voice trailed off."

Mifflin tops Hillsboro

FROM WIRE REPORTS

Aaron Turner scored 22 points and grabbed 10 rebounds yesterday to lead Columbus Mifflin over Hillsboro, 54-45, in a Division II boys basketball regional

BOYS ROUNDUP

final in Athens. Mifflin will face Benedictine Thursday at 3 p.m. in a state semifinal game in Columbus.

Mifflin (21-3) led throughout most of the game, but Hillsboro (18-6) stayed close and came within 46-43 with about three minutes left.

Mifflin outscored Hillsboro, 8-2, to seal the victory.

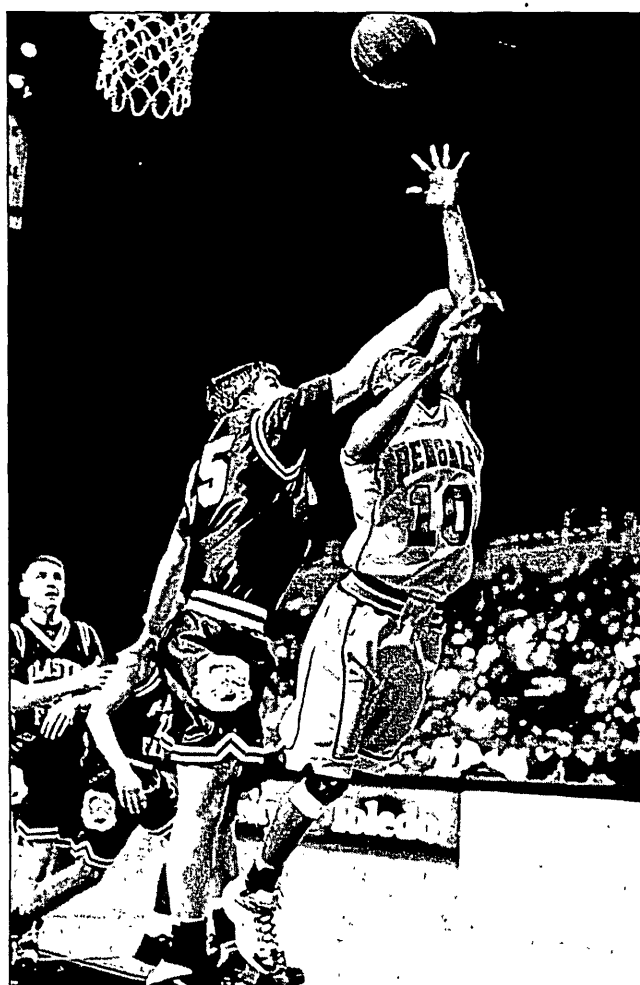
Andre Turner added 10 points for Mifflin.

Hamilton Badin 53, Cin. Roger Bacon 52 — Mark Pater's 6-foot jump shot with 1.3 seconds left gave Hamilton Badin a victory over Cincinnati Roger Bacon in a Division II regional championship in Dayton.

Roger Bacon (21-5) led, 24-21, at halftime and was ahead, 38-25, with 3:52 left in the third quarter. Badin (20-5) chipped away at the deficit and won it on Pater's shot. He finished with 12 points.

Dayton Christian 54, Cin. Wyoming 53 — Yaunta Holland scored with two seconds left to give Dayton Christian a victory over Cincinnati Wyoming in a Division III regional final in Dayton.

Christian (23-3) used a 15-5 run to open the third quarter and take a 39-28 lead. But Wyoming (12-14) closed to 41-37 at the end of the quarter.



Rashon Brown of Benedictine, right, shoots under pressure from Olmsted Falls' Dan Pellerite during Benedictine's 64-57 victory in a Division II regional championship game in Toledo yesterday.

Benedictine rides late surge past Olmsted Falls to state

By EDDIE DWYER
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

TOLEDO — Benedictine senior point guard Rashon Brown said he and his teammates never doubt their ability to overcome adversity.

That self-confidence, along with a wealth of talent, carried the Bengals to the biggest victory in the history of their basketball program.

Benedictine, overcoming a 10-point deficit with 4:27 remaining in the third quarter, defeated Olmsted Falls, 64-57, yesterday in a Division II boys regional championship game in the University of Toledo's Savage Hall.

The Bengals (21-5), ranked seventh in the final Associated Press Division II state poll, will make their first state final four appearance when they face Columbus Mifflin on Thursday at 3 p.m. in St. John Arena in Columbus.

"I have all the confidence in the world in this team," said Brown, who is as cool and calm off the court as he is on it. "I just knew that we would come on in the end and wear them down."

Olmsted Falls (23-2), which was making its third consecutive regional appearance and its fifth in coach Pat Donahue's eight seasons, led, 10-9, after 6-8 senior center Tim Schaefer hit a 3-pointer with 3:40 remaining in the first quarter.

The Bulldogs increased their lead to 16-11 on a jumper just in-

side the 3-point arc by senior point guard John Storey and held a 16-13 advantage entering the second quarter.

Schaefer, who totaled 51 points and 25 rebounds in two regional games, including 23 points yesterday, scored nine points in the first quarter.

Benedictine, which has been a slow-starting team all season, took a 22-21 lead on two free throws by Brown with 2:51 left in the first half. A first-team All-Northeast Lakes District selection, Brown scored 16 of his game-high 25 points in the first 16 minutes.

"We were struggling a bit at the start, so I was just trying to do whatever I could to keep us in the game," said Brown, who averaged 20.5 points during the regular season.

Working against full-court pressure, Olmsted Falls regained the lead, 27-24, on another 3-pointer by Schaefer with 1:44 to play in the first half. Hitting 10 of 17 shots from the field, the Bulldogs led, 29-26, at halftime.

"I tell you, that Schaefer is a great player," said Benedictine coach Frank Novak. "He hit some big shots in the first half. But, it was like Rashon said, I think our pressure finally got to them."

In the third quarter, Olmsted Falls, champion of the Southwestern Conference, pushed its lead to 34-28 on a 3-pointer by senior forward Dan Pellerite and a driving one-hander along the baseline by Storey.

The Bulldogs led, 40-30, after

Schaefer scored off an assist from Storey and sophomore guard Sean Radigan converted a steal into a layup with 4:27 remaining in the quarter.

"We had them playing our game," said Donahue, who guided Olmsted Falls to its best record in school history. "We had the tempo where we like it and we were getting the ball inside."

"But it's funny how these games go. They just increased their pressure and got all over us."

Benedictine, which trailed, 52-46, after Schaefer completed a three-point play with 3:35 remaining, scored more points (18) in the final three minutes than it did in any of the three previous quarters.

Picking up their defensive pressure and going strong to the offensive boards, the Bengals put together a decisive 15-3 run.

Showing the way were Brown, who scored off two crowd-pleasing moves down the lane, 6-7 junior center Albert Wilson, who started the run with a putback, and senior guard Todd Bacik, who gave the Bengals a 53-52 lead by hitting a 3-pointer with 2:37 left and came up with the game-breaker — a 3-pointer from the right side that made the score 60-55 with 1:18 to play.

"I thought winning the state title in football was the greatest thing that ever happened to me," said Bacik, a two-way standout on the Bengals' Division III state championship football team. "But to have this feeling twice in the same [school] year is amazing."